decades, the relatively higher pace of economic growth in China propelled a much larger volume of internal migration than in India, taking Chinese urbanization rates past 50 per cent. In comparison, India's urbanization rate rose gradually to a little over 30 per cent. At first glance, this may reflect low rates of spatial mobility but this artefact has more to do with definitions and rural–urban divergence in natural growth rates.[7] India's demographic transition began slowly in the first half of the 20th century and natural growth rates peaked in the 1980s but, curiously, since the 1970s, rural natural growth rates outstripped urban natural growth rates and dampened the process of urbanization. Even then, India is unique in having a large economic diversification taking place from agricultural to non-agricultural activities within rural areas themselves as cities have not been able to provide enough jobs for the rural poor.

The most remarkable aspect of Indian migration concerns itself with international migration. Standard development theory would predict India to be a country of net emigration and yet, since Independence, emigration has been balanced by immigration from the relatively poorer neighbouring countries of Nepal and Bangladesh. In every decade between 1971 and 2011, India was, in fact, a country of net immigration.[8] India's position in the global migration map is therefore fairly unique as it sustains considerable volumes of internal migration, emigration and immigration, alongside involuntary migration generated as a reaction to developmental activities.

Rags to Riches or Rages?

Bihar and Kerala stand poles apart on the ladder of development. Bihar is one of the poorest states of India, while Kerala is among the richest. On many indicators, Bihar fares worse than sub-Saharan Africa whereas Kerala mirrors countries in Europe. And yet, both states experience similar rates of outmigration, defying simplistic assumptions that poverty is the main driver of migration, especially from rural to urban areas. What unites Bihar and Kerala is an extremely high rate of rural population density that simply